

Alpaca Setup & App Connection Guide

Step-by-step instructions to create an Alpaca account, enable 2FA, generate API keys, and connect Alpaca to your trading app.

Part 1 — Create the Alpaca account

- 1 Go to <https://alpaca.markets> → click **Sign Up** (top right).
- 2 Pick the account type:
 - **Paper Trading** — free, instant, \$100K virtual money. Start here for testing.
 - **Live Trading (Individual)** — real money, requires identity verification (SSN/ID upload, takes 1–2 days to approve).
- 1 Enter email + password. Verify the email link they send.
- 2 **(Live only)** Complete identity verification:
 - Legal name, DOB, address
 - SSN / tax ID
 - Government ID upload
 - Employment + financial questions
 - Bank account link (ACH) for funding
- 1 **(Live only)** Wait for approval email (usually <24h, sometimes longer).

Tip: Even if you plan to go live, enable a paper account too — Alpaca gives both, and you can switch your app between them with the same login but different API keys. Test the copy flow in paper first.

Part 2 — Enable 2FA on Alpaca

- 1 Log in at <https://app.alpaca.markets>.
- 2 Top-right → click your profile icon → **Account** (or **Settings**).
- 3 Find **Security** → **Two-Factor Authentication** → **Enable**.
- 4 Pick **Authenticator App (TOTP)** — preferred over SMS.
- 5 Scan the QR code with Google Authenticator / Authy / 1Password / your password manager.
- 6 Enter the 6-digit code shown in the app to confirm.
- 7 Save the **recovery / backup codes** they show you somewhere safe (1Password, a file you don't lose). If you lose your phone, those codes are the only way back in.

From now on, the Alpaca dashboard login will ask for the 6-digit code. The API keys themselves do **NOT** use 2FA — they're a separate machine credential. 2FA only protects the human dashboard.

Part 3 — Generate API keys

- 1 Still in **https://app.alpaca.markets**, top-left of the dashboard, make sure you're in the right environment:
 - **Paper** (default for fresh accounts) — keys only work on paper endpoints.
 - **Live** — switch using the toggle in the top-left of the dashboard.
- 1 Right sidebar → **API Keys** section → click **Generate New Key** (or **View** if one already exists).
- 2 Alpaca shows you two values **once**:
 - **API Key ID** (looks like PKxxxxxxx for paper, AKxxxxxxx for live)
 - **Secret Key** (long random string)
- 1 Copy both immediately into a password manager. The secret is shown only once — if you lose it you have to regenerate.
- 2 Repeat for the other environment if you want both paper + live keys. (Your app only lets one broker be connected per user at a time, but you can switch.)

Part 4 — Log into your app

- 1 Open your app — locally that's `http://localhost:3000`, or your deployed URL.
- 2 Click **Sign in** (or **Sign up** if you haven't registered yet).
- 3 Sign in with your app email + password (the eye icon on the password field lets you peek at what you typed).
- 4 After login, the app routes you based on role:
 - **Trader** → `/trade-panel`
 - **Subscriber** → `/trades`

Part 5 — Connect Alpaca in the app

- 1 In the left nav, click **Brokers**.
- 2 You'll see the three broker tiles: **Alpaca**, **Webull**, **SnapTrade**. Click the **Alpaca** tile.
- 3 Fill in the connection form:
 - **Label** (required) — something memorable like *My Paper Alpaca* or *Live Alpaca*. Just a display name.
 - **Mode** — radio buttons for **Paper** or **Live**. Defaults to Live, but for first testing pick **Paper** and use your paper keys.
 - **API Key ID** — paste the PKxxxxxxx (paper) or AKxxxxxxx (live) value.
 - **API Secret** — paste the secret. (Password input — eye icon to verify before submitting.)
- 1 Click **Connect**.